PRELUDE XIX

THE *tempo* of this little Pastorale is given by two details—viz., the swinging bass figure in the first part of bar 2, and the cadence in bar 9, where, by the way, the treble pretends to be a new part in the middle of the bar. Bars 20-21 are another incident demanding leisure for its appreciation in performance. With the best tone-production the piece will easily bear a *tempo* no faster than that of the Pastorale in the *Christmas Oratorio*. (The Pastorale in the *Messiah* represents a *tempo* just too slow for this.) No *ritardando* or *rubato* is advisable. As usual with Bach, this piece must first be grasped in big paragraphs, the more so as its phrases are of irregular lengths, more like Handel's than the four-bar rhythms which are so inexhaustible in Bach's treatment of melodic forms. The first paragraph ends with the above-mentioned close in the dominant in the middle of bar 9; the division after the first quarter of bar 6 being self-evident, but (as will afterwards appear) less important to the whole design. At the beginning of bar 9, however, the bass has already undermined the cadence by starting the inversion of the main figure. This the other parts take up, and a development ensues (on the direct figure). Laying no stress on the close in F♯ minor at bar 16, this development works its way back to the dominant of A in bar 19, and leads back to the tonic by the same bar (an octave lower) that led to the development. (The *appoggiatura* is written by Bach in his usual indefinite notation as a quaver; the dotted crotchet is the best value here.) Now comes a formal appearance of beginning again in the tonic, and perhaps no single note has ever combined more threads of the musical history of three centuries than the second bass-note of bar 20 with its gesture of behaving like a merely homophonic bass contented to devote itself to marking key-notes. With bar 21, however, the bass revives and again, in terms of bars 9 and 19, leads to the subdominant. In that key we have a recapitulation of bars 1-9 with happy new lights on the tonality (compare bars $2\frac{1}{2}$-3 with bars $23\frac{1}{2}$-24, and note other details later), and with the upper parts interchanged. This, of course, leads to the tonic, closing therein at bar 30, on to which is grafted a Coda (over a tonic pedal) by the same means as that which grafted the little development on to bar 9.

FUGUE XIX

THE syncopations of the Subject turn out to be identical with the ordinary dotted rhythms of the other parts into which they dovetail. A playfully jerky antiphonal dialogue should be expressed by means of this fact, which thus determines the *tempo* of the piece within narrow limits; too much accent to be quite satisfied by counting four in the bar, but far too brisk a trot for eight. (Remember that counting is not the same as conducting; good conductors prefer to beat twice as slow when counting becomes quick.) In the right *tempo* a temptation will be felt (and may reasonably be indulged) to treat these dotted rhythms (both normally and in cross rhythm) slightly in *stile francese* as Bach understands it—*les double-croches un tant-soit-peu pointées*, as Couperin once indicated—*i.e.*, those semiquavers that follow a dotted or tied note arriving just so late as to jerk a little nervously towards the next notes. The second figure of the Subject forms a smooth current to carry the whole; and, both direct and inverted (see already bar 6), is the staple of the Episodes. With its aid the Fugue remains graceful throughout, and the playful raillery of the syncopations and dotted rhythms need never assume a nagging expression.

The readings of some of the Altnikol MSS. are evidently authentic final improvements on the British Museum autograph, and are accordingly adopted here, with the exception of the delightful bottom notes in bar 16, which presumably had to be sacrificed to the instrument Altnikol had at home. (Throughout Book II. Bach writes for larger instruments than were available to him for Book I.)

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